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Boyhood rituals in an African society

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Mgbom village, Afikpo village group, southeastern Nigeria

Section Title(S): Initiation Day

It is said that in former times you had to be a very strong person to take the dog to a bush for the sacrifice, for the young society members were very rough with their sticks; they would knock the dog basket down and kill the animal. The sacrifice could not be done with a dead dog; so another would have to be found.

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In 1960 two men came late to the bush with their dogs and other materials, bringing money for the priests, having failed to pay the notification fee ahead of time. The man guarding the tunnel entrance took the coins away and threw them in the bush, saying that this was no good, that they should have brought the money beforehand. For, as in the case of clothes, anything brought to the bush (except people, dogs, the priests' gong, and the sacred stone) cannot be returned; certainly they cannot go back into public circulation but must remain in the bush or the dressing shed areas, the men's rest houses, or the society's shrine house. The two men were permitted to do their sacrifices but had to pay a shilling fine in addition to the regular fee. After this incident a man standing nearby suddenly realized that he had two metal rings on. He disgustedly took them off and threw them away.

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These rules stress the separation of the society and its activities from the everyday world; the latter is easily contaminated by the spiritual qualities of

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the secret bush world. Once in the bush an initiand has to be initiated; there is no turning back, for he knows some of the secrets. To return would place him in an intermediate position, violating the distinction between the two worlds.

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In the bush there is sometimes competition between compounds, whose helpers and initiands group together to push ahead of other compounds. The contest can be spirited. If an initiand dies, faints, or gets sick there, men of the village joke with men of the compound that the boy comes from, saying, "Your compound is weak. What have you been doing? Your boy is left behind." These kinds of statements are also made of the initiands who come back last from the bush. Compound males take pride in getting their sons through ²⁷⁴the rite on time and in good condition. The initiands themselves are well aware of this competitive situation; for them it is an extension of their intercompound fights and competitive events of earlier days, and they are anxious to finish up in good order.

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Sodalities

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